

AI Research

OpenAI Frontier and the Impact on Microsoft, AWS and the Broader Software Sector

Equities

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Software

Summary

In early-Feb, OpenAI announced Frontier, described as a “a new platform that helps enterprises build, deploy, and manage AI agents” and the latest new push by OpenAI into the enterprise market. Frontier is important for tech investors to monitor for several reasons – ostensibly it overlaps directly with the AI agent efforts of software incumbents such as Salesforce and ServiceNow, it strengthens the AWS-OpenAI partnership as AWS was named Frontier’s “exclusive” distribution provider and it has positives and negatives for Microsoft. We spoke to two large enterprise customers of OpenAI and share their candid views of Frontier in this report.

What it Means for OpenAI

Frontier is one element of OpenAI’s larger aim to increase its enterprise mix, now at an estimated 40-45% of total revs. We think of Frontier as being part of the third leg of OpenAI’s enterprise stool – with ChatGPT for enterprise and OpenAI Codex being the higher-profile and/or more mature avenues to scale in the enterprise. If adoption of AI agents for use cases beyond coding – in sales, marketing, customer support, knowledge work – does take off in 2026/2027, and many of these agents will harness OpenAI models as their reasoning engine, then Frontier and other OpenAI “enterprise agent” products could be material incremental revenue sources that serve to broaden the utilization of OpenAI models.

Impact on AWS and Azure

The roll-out of OpenAI Frontier is very early-stage, but if Frontier serves as even a modest tailwind to enterprise AI agent adoption, it is clear that enterprise spend with their cloud infrastructure providers goes up. This is good for AWS in particular as OpenAI appointed AWS as the exclusive GTM partner for Frontier. For Microsoft, Frontier is still a positive for Azure IF (here is where the investor debate is) Frontier-on-AWS still requires a stateless API call back to Azure (Microsoft sounds confident that it will), but a potential headwind if/as Frontier accelerates the use of 3P AI agents to do “knowledge work” tasks.

Impact on Software Incumbents

With Frontier, OpenAI is going beyond selling model access via APIs to selling a broader platform or AI middleware layer to ease agent deployment and step right into the “agent orchestration” layer that several application software firms are aiming for. That said, Frontier sits on (doesn’t displace) core systems of record and what Frontier is really trying to address is the complexity inside most organizations that limit AI agent performance, complexities that one could argue Microsoft, Salesforce, ServiceNow and Workday are better suited to address. At the data layer, Frontier integrates into the existing data stack and while portions of Frontier (its semantic layer, the use of FDEs) sound like Palantir, we conclude that any success of Frontier in “unlocking” the value of corporate data is probably a good thing for the data incumbents.

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What is OpenAI Frontier?

Throughout most of last year, OpenAI spoke about 2025 being “the year of agents”. While the timing was off by about a year – it now looks more likely that 2026 will be the year of enterprise AI agent adoption – OpenAI announced a number of platforms to help enterprises build AI agentic applications. These included Agent Builder, Agents SDK (software development kit) and then the Agent Kit that OpenAI highlighted at its October 2025 DevDay. Frontier looks to be an extension of these earlier efforts, with a focus on the “AI middleware” elements that enterprises need to safely and reliably run AI agents.

OpenAI Frontier

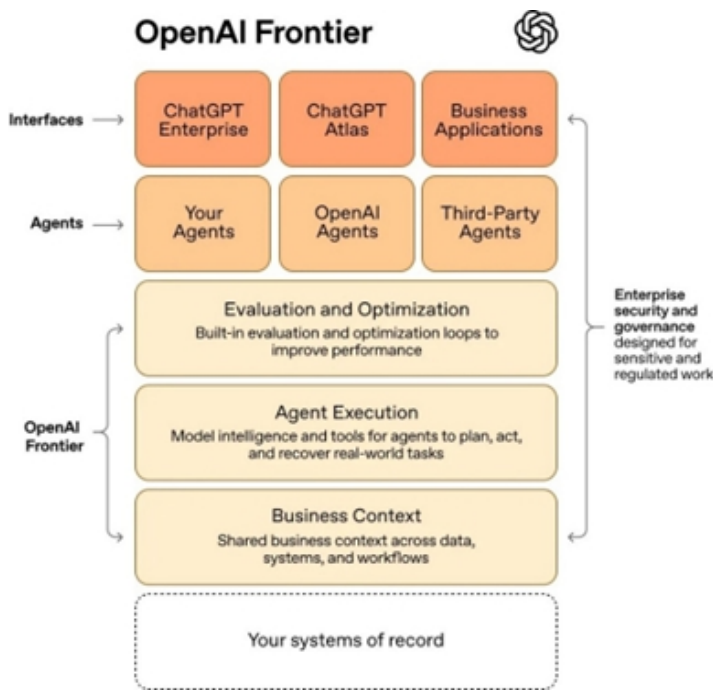
In early February 2026, OpenAI took the concept of an enterprise AI agent development platform further via the announcement of Frontier, which OpenAI described as “a new platform that helps enterprises build, deploy, and manage AI agents that can do real work”. OpenAI went on to say:

- *“The challenge to deploying enterprise AI agents is not model intelligence, it’s the surrounding and fragmented systems and governance layers as well as the lack of context and the need for control. Frontier is intended to offer a more end-to-end approach by utilizing the technology that a customer already has, without a need to re-platform. Frontier connects siloed data warehouses, CRM systems, ticketing tools, and internal applications to give AI coworkers that same shared business context. It becomes a semantic layer for the enterprise that all AI coworkers can reference to operate and communicate effectively”.*

An AI Middleware Layer

As Figure 1 depicts, Frontier is essentially a new middleware layer that enables AI agents to be successful, providing security and governance, agent optimization and management and a “business context” layer at the bottom of the stack that offers integration with the requisite data and systems of record. This layer is powered by OpenAI’s Codex model. While Frontier can be the agentic middleware layer for custom-built and even third-party agents, we’re assuming that enterprises will harness Frontier for OpenAI-powered agents. Today, enterprises deploying AI agents in production are themselves stitching together this middleware or “scaffolding” to improve the performance and security of AI agents, with Frontier intended to serve as a pre-packaged substitute. As Figure 1 below depicts, OpenAI is NOT positioning Frontier as displacing the systems of record; rather, it sits on top.

Figure 1: OpenAI Frontier Stack



Source: OpenAI

Frontier Use Cases

OpenAI is positioning Frontier as an AI middleware layer or single platform for AI agent adoption, for a variety of use cases. OpenAI is not being overly prescriptive in terms of use cases, although the company clearly has a focus on the large "knowledge work" opportunity, which implies direct overlap with Microsoft's large Office franchise as well as other application software categories. Zooming out, we can imagine OpenAI focusing on enterprise use cases for which the ROI from deploying AI is measurable – coding, customer support, knowledge work and research. In the press release, OpenAI did give an example, saying that Frontier provides the technical foundation enabling an AI agent to *"resolve a customer issue end-to-end by pulling context from the CRM, checking policies, filing the update, and escalating only when needed"*. That pretty clearly sounds like overlap with how Salesforce would like its customers to use Agentforce. OpenAI also said that Frontier-managed agents can *"pull together simulation logs, internal docs, workflows, and code, then run an end-to-end investigation to identify the most likely root cause and what to do next"*. That sounds like basic incident response, tasks that a product like PagerDuty might do. When OpenAI cited its AgentKit offering at the October 2025 DevDay, we concluded AgentKit appeared to be focused on lightweight and easy-to-build agents, not complex "enterprise-grade" agents. While it's still very early, on the surface it seems as if Frontier is being positioned to handle more complex enterprise tasks.

Alliances With McKinsey, BCG, Accenture, Cap Gemini

Soon after announcing Frontier, OpenAI also announced partnerships with four consulting and SI services firms, including McKinsey, BCG, Accenture and Cap Gemini. According to OpenAI, these firms will "help customers define strategy, integrate systems, redesign workflows, and scale deployment globally. We're entering multi-year partnerships with each firm to help deploy AI coworkers across the enterprise". OpenAI is pushing harder to penetrate enterprise customers against a backdrop of having a very small sales, implementation and FDE footprint, such that OpenAI can benefit materially from any pull-through from these established enterprise services partners. This is not unique to OpenAI, as Anthropic, Palantir and others are forming similar partnerships. We're unclear on the direct revenue lift to these services firms, as it's not obvious to us that Frontier (and in general the bespoke agentic application development process) has a material services pull-through (it's more services-light, AI coding-heavy).

Frontier Customer Feedback

When OpenAI announced Frontier, the company said that it is “available today to a limited set of customers, with broader availability coming over the next few months”. These initial customers were identified as HP, Intuit, Oracle, State Farm, Thermo Fisher and Uber, as well as dozens of existing customers such as BBVA, Cisco and T-Mobile. To sharpen our view of Frontier, we spoke with IT executives at two such customers and offer their unvarnished feedback below.

Frontier is Very Early-Stage

- **Customer 1:** *Some components of Frontier are not even GA yet. For instance, the bottom data layer hasn't really been announced yet.*
- **Customer 2:** *Frontier is really an early-stage co-development initiative with a handful of large customers to find use cases and shape the product. I would expect the first Frontier-based agents in the next 3-6 months. The product is mostly marketing right now, it's not built out yet.*

What Frontier Does

- **Customer 1:** *In our view Frontier has good product-market fit. AI agents are hard to build, think of Frontier as a bundle to address pain points to make agent development practical, to help build internal agents for knowledge workers. First, you need a rapid agent builder or studio. It also offers things like automated testing on agents and at the data layer it is really a caching or data permissioning layer. For enterprise agents to be performant, they cannot suffer from 30-second delays, they need a low-latency caching layer. Think of Frontier as being an agent SDK, we'll consider using it to automate customer support, marketing and HR functions. We're looking to automate more knowledge work via agents. Improving agent performance isn't just about model intelligence, using GPT-5.3 for instance. It's also about data readiness.*
- **Customer 2:** *Think of Frontier as a knowledge graph on your data, producing better agents by adding context via enriching them with your own data. It is integrated with OpenAI's Agent SDK. It's all about addressing agent complexity, getting agents into actual production.*

What is OpenAI's “Right to Win”?

As investors know, the race is on to be the enterprise platform that AI agents are built on. Just one month after OpenAI announced its Frontier agent management platform, Microsoft announced a new M365 E7 bundle “to accelerate customer adoption of secure, agent-enabled AI at scale” – a platform that Microsoft is calling “Frontier”. Microsoft's E7 bundle includes Agent 365 to govern and control AI agents as well as its Entra suite for identity and access control, features described in OpenAI's Frontier platform. Application software firms including ServiceNow and Salesforce have also announced AI agent management platforms. Anthropic has launched its own Claude Agent SDK (and we wouldn't be shocked if Anthropic launched something akin to OpenAI Frontier) and the hyperscalers all offer platforms to enable enterprise customers to more easily build agentic AI applications, including AWS Bedrock, Microsoft Foundry (including Azure AI Foundry SDK) and Google Vertex AI Agent Builder. This market is competitive.

What makes OpenAI competitive here? One obvious answer is that OpenAI Frontier could be a natural choice for enterprises (such as T-Mobile) that sign larger deals with OpenAI and elect to run the bulk of their AI agents and applications on OpenAI models. Many more will likely take a more diversified approach and for these customers, OpenAI would argue that it has an open eco-system, with Frontier serving as an agent management platform for even 3P agents from the likes of Sierra. But Microsoft would counter that if the trend is to a multi-model approach, then a trusted platform – a model-neutral player such as Microsoft – is the more natural counter-party for customers to manage agent sprawl when those agents harness a host of underlying AI models. We're sympathetic to that argument. Microsoft also argues that its E7 Frontier platform, while not GA until May 1st, is a finished product, in contrast to OpenAI Frontier that is still a work-in-progress (as customers mentioned above).

Do Model Providers Have an Agent Advantage?

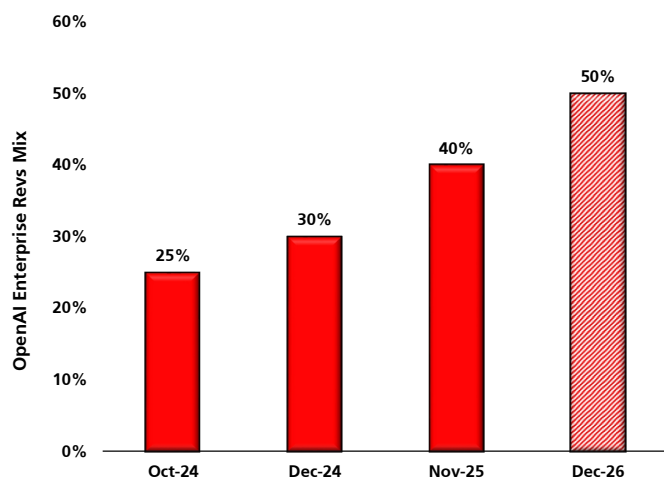
One question we have – and we don't have an answer yet – is whether technically, the frontier model providers – OpenAI or Anthropic or Google – are better-positioned than others such as Microsoft and ServiceNow to build the tooling to manage digital agents. In other words, does the expertise acquired via model training confer an advantage in terms of integrating the model and the agent and optimizing the tooling and environment that agents run on? Does Codex give OpenAI an edge because it produces the harness (in AI terminology, the framework around a model that allows for API management, scoring, orchestration and monitoring) through which agents interact? One potential analogy here is that the expertise acquired by Anthropic and OpenAI in building coding-optimized models may be giving them a leg up in terms of building non-coding AI applications, a reality that motivated many VC firms in 2025 to pivot to a view that the frontier model providers – as opposed to 3P AI application vendors – may end up winning a larger-than-expected portion of the enterprise AI opportunity. We need to explore this topic further.

UBS Bottom Line – Expanding OpenAI's Enterprise Portfolio

Strategically, in our view Frontier is a key new growth vector for OpenAI to press further into the enterprise customer segment, going beyond selling ChatGPT for Enterprise or OpenAI Codex seats. Frontier is one new element of OpenAI's larger aim to increase its enterprise mix, now at an estimated 40-45% of total revs. Assuming that OpenAI is now at a revenue run-rate of \$25+ billion, then its enterprise segment is now a \$10+ billion business (our understanding is that OpenAI reports revenues net of any 3P associated cloud vendor revenues). These figures could be even higher given the very recent traction of GPT 5.4 (especially in Codex)—which Greg Brockman shared in mid-March “has ramped faster than any other model we've launched in the API” and “within a week of launch” had already reached “an annualized run rate of \$1B in net new revenue”—and Sam Altman's tweet from mid-January that OpenAI has “added more than \$1 billion of ARR in the last month just from our API business”. We're unclear what portion of rival Anthropic's “reported” revenue ramp over the last few weeks/months is truly enterprise versus prosumer/AI-native, but suffice to say that OpenAI already has a material presence and branding in the large enterprise segment, in part because of its scale and success in the consumer AI space with ChatGPT.

We think of Frontier as an extension of OpenAI's growing enterprise portfolio, going beyond ChatGPT for Enterprise, Codex and the enterprise API business. If adoption of AI agents for use cases beyond coding – in sales, marketing, customer support, knowledge work – does take off in 2026/2027, and many of these agents will harness OpenAI models as their reasoning engine, then Frontier and other OpenAI “enterprise agent” products could be material incremental revenue sources that serve to broaden the utilization of OpenAI models.

Figure 2: Mix of OpenAI Revs from Enterprise



Source: The Information, OpenAI

Implications for AWS and Microsoft

Our keen interest in OpenAI Frontier also stems from the fact that there are very clear implications for Microsoft and AWS in particular.

AWS – Distribution Exclusivity

The launch of Frontier was followed 1-2 weeks later by an announcement naming Amazon Web Services (AWS) as the “exclusive third-party cloud distribution provider” for Frontier. As Amazon investors assess the materiality of the Frontier-AWS “exclusivity”, it’s important to note the precise language here – AWS was appointed the exclusive **distribution** partner. That means that AWS has a sales or go-to-market (GTM) exclusivity, very different from hosting exclusivity (and indeed, as we flag below, OpenAI followed up by confirming that OpenAI Frontier can be hosted on Azure). Practically though, we would imagine that the bulk of customers will elect to host their OpenAI Frontier deployments on AWS, a win for AWS. This deal clearly strengthens the AWS-OpenAI relationship, which is important for OpenAI to nurture as enterprise agent adoption ramps and the millions of commercial customers utilizing AWS represent an ever-increasing target market for OpenAI. The “exclusivity” with AWS (not Microsoft Azure) also makes sense in the context of OpenAI and Microsoft clearly becoming direct rivals in the market for enterprise AI agent management.

No Change to the OpenAI-Microsoft Agreement

On February 27th, immediately after the OpenAI-AWS agreement, OpenAI issued a separate blogpost on the OpenAI-Microsoft agreement (the timing of which was such that it’s hard for us not to wonder if this was a reaction to Microsoft issues/concerns with the elements of the AWS Frontier agreement). In this blog were some key points we think are worth flagging:

- **No Change to the Microsoft Agreement:** OpenAI said that the Microsoft-OpenAI partnership “remains strong and central” and “nothing about today’s announcements (with AWS) in any way changes the terms of the Microsoft and OpenAI relationship that have been previously shared in our joint blog in October 2025”.
- **New OpenAI Products on Other Cloud Providers:** The October 2025 agreement with Microsoft said that “OpenAI can now jointly develop some products with third parties” and “non-API products may be served on any cloud provider”. Ostensibly, OpenAI Frontier is a new and non-API product and hence the notion that OpenAI is running Frontier on AWS appears to fit with this partnership wording. In the February 27th post, OpenAI said that “collaborations like the partnership between OpenAI and Amazon were always contemplated under our agreements”. New and non-API OpenAI products hosted on Azure rivals serve as foregone workloads for Microsoft, but realistically, OpenAI was likely never going to run all new products on Azure and Microsoft would likely resist that anyway (too much OpenAI concentration). As we noted above, OpenAI Frontier may actually compete with Microsoft’s own E7 Frontier suite, such that OpenAI hosting Frontier primarily on Azure was likely never in the cards anyway.
- **Revs Share:** OpenAI said that “the ongoing revenue share arrangement remains unchanged and has always included sharing revenue from partnerships between OpenAI and other cloud providers”. This is incremental, confirming that the revenue share is on total OpenAI revenues, even if generated via the AWS agreement.

Stateless on Azure, Stateful on AWS

At the same time that OpenAI designated AWS as the exclusive distribution provider for Frontier, it also named AWS as a co-creator of “a stateful runtime environment” powered by OpenAI models and available on AWS Bedrock. As OpenAI described, “stateful” environments allow developers to “keep context and remember prior work” and are designed to handle ongoing projects and workflows. Enterprise AI agents must be context-aware, have “memory” and therefore need a “stateful” runtime environment or SRE. This is in contrast to one-off or “stateless” ChatGPT inference workloads or API calls, basically separate transactions or prompts without memory (not retaining previous activity). This seemingly obscure “stateful versus stateless” technical difference took on new importance with Frontier, as we discuss below.

Microsoft Exclusivity on Stateless OpenAI API Calls

In the October 2025 agreement, Microsoft retained OpenAI API exclusivity, with the agreement stating that API products developed with third parties will still be exclusive to Azure. Although the October 2025 agreement didn’t explicitly include any language about “stateful” versus “stateless” OpenAI workloads, Microsoft’s CEO brought this up on a podcast shortly after, saying that the agreement gave Microsoft exclusivity to host “stateless” OpenAI API calls through 2032. As noted above, OpenAI’s CEO recently tweeted that OpenAI has “added more than \$1 billion of ARR in the last month just from our API business”. Microsoft’s exclusivity on hosting those API calls is a big deal, a major component of the OpenAI agreement. In the February 27th follow-up, OpenAI confirmed (for the first time) that “Microsoft is the exclusive cloud provider for stateless APIs that provide access to OpenAI’s models and IP. These APIs can be purchased from Microsoft or directly from OpenAI”.

Do SREs Require a Stateless API Call?

Here is the important potential gray zone. Do products such as OpenAI Frontier – deployed in an AWS-hosted stateful run-time environment or SRE – still require a stateless API call to access the OpenAI model? If yes, then that associated API call must, according to the Microsoft-OpenAI agreement, go via Azure and represents a key revenue source for Microsoft, especially as enterprise AI agent adoption ramps. If no, then the OpenAI Frontier-AWS deal appears to serve as a way to avoid an API call via Azure and effectively waters-down the value of the API exclusivity that Microsoft secured as part of the October 2025 agreement. Bigger picture, it could signal a crack in the Microsoft-OpenAI relationship. While acknowledging that OpenAI Frontier is not a finished and deployed product and hence it may be too early to draw conclusions, Microsoft appears to be arguing that the Frontier SRE hosted on AWS **will still require an API call** via Azure.

The language from OpenAI was in our view unclear on this key subject. In its February 27th blog, OpenAI clarified that “any stateless API calls to OpenAI models that result from a collaboration between OpenAI and any third party—including Amazon—would be hosted on Azure. OpenAI’s first party products, including Frontier, will continue to be hosted on Azure”. This is critical, clarifying that Frontier can indeed be hosted on Azure, but it does not clearly state whether the Frontier platform hosted on AWS generates stateless API calls served by Azure. This is what we and Microsoft investors want to know. For now, we’re defaulting to a view that yes, an AWS-hosted Frontier platform will still generate stateless API calls served by Azure.

FT Report of Microsoft Objections

Last week, the Financial Times (see link to story [here](#)) published an article saying that Microsoft was weighing legal action against both OpenAI and Amazon related to the OpenAI Frontier announcement and the broader OpenAI-AWS cloud commitment and recent \$50 billion planned Amazon investment in OpenAI. In particular, FT stated that the dispute centers on the Frontier exclusivity described above and whether the “stateful runtime environment” or SRE that AWS will stand up violates Microsoft’s exclusivity on OpenAI model access via stateless API calls by essentially working around the need for OpenAI model API calls through Azure. This is one reason why we described this stateful-stateless technical issue above.

We don’t have any insights into what Microsoft might or might not do in this context, but we’d offer a few key observations that we think argue against the idea that this would result in a lawsuit between Microsoft and OpenAI with any material impact.

- The OpenAI Frontier platform as described above is very new – it’s not even fully built out yet – and the AWS exclusivity is about GTM, not hosting. In our view OpenAI Frontier is unlikely to be a material revenue source for AWS for some time. As such, in our view it is unlikely that any legal dispute from Microsoft related to the associated API mechanics and revenues could possibly jeopardize the broader OpenAI-AWS investment or cloud commitment (including details such as OpenAI’s Trainium 2 purchase commitment) as the FT article implies. Frontier is simply far too small a part of the broader OpenAI-AWS agreement to have this material an impact.
- Microsoft seems adamant that AI “stateful runtime environments” or SREs almost always involve a need to access a model (in this case OpenAI’s) via a stateless API call. They are not 100% on this regarding Frontier, as it’s still in development, but given Microsoft’s conviction as well as the early state of OpenAI Frontier, it strikes us as too premature for this topic to be rising to the level of a lawsuit that could be detrimental to the Microsoft-OpenAI relationship.
- The Microsoft partnership is also critical to OpenAI, as Azure is OpenAI’s primary compute provider and Microsoft serves as a key distribution network for OpenAI to scale in the enterprise market. It seems highly unlikely to us that OpenAI would jeopardize the Microsoft relationship over an extremely small revenue stream associated with API calls on Frontier.

UBS Bottom Line – A Tailwind for Microsoft and AWS

AI agents need compute like humans need food, water and air. If OpenAI’s Frontier serves as even a modest tailwind to enterprise AI adoption, it is clear that enterprise spend with their cloud infrastructure providers goes up. This is good for AWS and Azure and all their underlying chip and hardware suppliers. AWS was late to build a material revenue source from the LLMs themselves (this first accrued to Microsoft and Google) but AWS will win if/as its massive enterprise base begins to deploy AI applications and agents, and the AWS-Frontier deal helps, even if modestly. For Microsoft, enterprise AI adoption is both a gift and a threat. It’s a gift as Azure, M365 Copilot and GitHub Copilot get pulled along (and it appears as if Azure still benefits from Frontier), but it’s a threat to the Office franchise as ever-improving 3P AI agents increasingly can do “knowledge work” tasks. In our view the net of all this is still a positive for Microsoft, even if OpenAI spending share starts drifting to rival AWS.

Overlap with Software Firms

The OpenAI Frontier announcement also has implications on other application and data software firms, not just on Microsoft Azure and AWS as OpenAI cloud infrastructure partners. Let's start with what our customer checks said about the overlap between OpenAI Frontier and other software firms.

Frontier Customer Feedback

Customer 1

- *For the "rapid agent builder" part of Frontier, there are incumbent tools out there. We use Distyl AI, which sells a very good product [UBS: Distyl is an AI start-up that recently raised at a \$1.8 billion valuation and co-founded by a former Palantir exec]. We'll keep using Distyl until Frontier features sufficiently improve. Others in this space include Microsoft with Copilot Studio and Google and Sierra also sell agent builders. For data permissioning, there is Microsoft Graph, an API that accesses data across the M365 suite. At the data caching layer, you can use MongoDB or Microsoft CosmosDB as an agent-facing data store, we happen to use MongoDB. I'm not sure whether OpenAI will just leverage these 3P data systems or go in-house.*
- *As you work with AI agents, you're less tied to the underlying software. For instance, for knowledge work tasks, the agent doesn't care if you're using a Word document or a markdown file [UBS: a plain-text document that formats via the Markdown language]. I can see a world in which one uses agents and you can move away from Office, such that work done in Office is vulnerable to what you can build and manage in Frontier. But this will take a long time to impact our Office spend, as only ~2% of our knowledge workers are really using agents, it's way too early for agents to be impacting our Microsoft spend. I think Frontier could compete with Genesys, Sierra and Microsoft. As we leverage more agents, whether through Frontier or not, our spend with the hyperscalers goes up, more token use, more data, more caching, this all boosts spending with the cloud providers. Microsoft could also win at the agent orchestration layer, they're very well-positioned here, as getting agents to work is really hard, but there will be competition here from OpenAI and Google.*

Customer 2

- *In some ways it's like Palantir, as Frontier is a semantic layer and OpenAI is offering FDEs to sit with us to co-develop agents.*
- *OpenAI is not trying to replace Salesforce but Frontier can be thought of as competing with Agentforce for sure. AI agents rely on source data from the likes of Salesforce and Workday, OpenAI is trying to build on top of these systems of records. Our sales and marketing team, for instance, is trying to build agents to improve sales rep productivity. The rep might be on his/her way to meet a client, they need info, think of it as sales call prep. We can build an agent for that. I can imagine that Frontier-built agents might also replace UiPath.*

Overlap With SaaS/Application Software Firms

As investors in Salesforce, ServiceNow and other application software stocks are aware, these software firms are themselves trying to sell enterprises a full agent management platform and not just the digital agent itself (think Salesforce selling a complete "Agentforce platform" to handle most of the tasks described above that Frontier could handle). Likewise, OpenAI is describing Frontier as a platform to manage agents (OpenAI-based as well as third-party agents), which sounds a lot like the "agent orchestration layer" that the likes of Salesforce and ServiceNow are positioning themselves to win. As AI product upsells become a key growth driver for the application software firms, the fact that OpenAI is now stepping firmly into this AI middleware market (going well beyond merely selling model access or APIs) is a big deal and one reason we elected to dig into Frontier in more depth. In our view it is inevitable that Anthropic enhances its own Claude Agent SDK offering and sells something similar. Increased overlap with software providers is real, not hypothetical.

At first blush, OpenAI Frontier is a negative for software incumbents trying to sell their own agentic applications. Today, enterprises can custom-build AI applications by harnessing OpenAI models via API calls instead of buying 3P AI products from Salesforce, ServiceNow and Workday. Indeed, many are doing just that. With Frontier, OpenAI is going beyond selling model access via APIs to selling a broader platform or middleware layer to ease this process and improve agent output. In the process, they may take share from incumbents and step right into the “agent orchestration” layer that several application software firms are aiming for. That said, what Frontier is really addressing is the complexity – the many sources of messiness – inside most organizations that limit AI agent performance and hence adoption. Is OpenAI – with limited enterprise traction outside of selling model access and ChatGPT – best-suited to help organizations overcome those enterprise hurdles? Or are the likes of Microsoft, Salesforce, ServiceNow and Workday better suited given that they’ve been a core part of the tech stack of most enterprises for 10+ years?

As noted above, OpenAI is NOT positioning Frontier as displacing application systems of record (SoR). Rather, it sits on top, offering a “business context” layer that integrates with the requisite data and SoR. But even in this role, OpenAI Frontier could have implications for the providers of the SoR. Does Frontier serving as the data context layer and accessing a SoR end up weakening the value of that SoR, turning it into a “dumb database”? Do we end up seeing more partnerships between the SoRs and the likes of OpenAI and Anthropic, whereby they negotiate an equitable economic split? This topic is very early-stage and evolving, one we hope to explore in more detail.

Overlap With Data Software Firms

In the Frontier announcement, OpenAI said that *“many agent apps fail for a simple reason: they don’t have the context they need. Data is scattered across systems, permissions are complex, and each integration becomes a one-off project”*. That argument – echoed by Nvidia CEO last week during his GTC keynote – has been the bull case for data software stocks like Palantir and Snowflake – that enterprises need to invest in “data readiness” (and are). The notion that Frontier serves as a “semantic layer” on corporate data and that OpenAI “Forward Deployed Engineers” or FDEs will work with customers sounds like an effort to look more like Palantir. But in the same way that OpenAI is positioning Frontier to sit on and utilize the core systems of record, it appears to us that Frontier offers connectors to but doesn’t replace the data layer either.

The data software layer and incumbents such as Palantir, Databricks, Snowflake and MongoDB are widely viewed as being far more insulated from AI disruption than most other corners of the software market. We buy into that view. But there have been a few signals from OpenAI in particular that there IS some overlap, not just with Frontier aiming to be a “semantic layer” on corporate data (that sounds like Palantir’s real estate) but also OpenAI’s blog post from late January (see [here](#)) about its in-house data agent (which struck us as competitive with Tableau and even Snowflake Cortex). But in the same way that OpenAI and Anthropic don’t appear to be targeting the underlying systems of record, they don’t appear to be keen to replicate the data stack. Rather, Frontier is a mechanism to harness the valuable data of organizations even more. If LLMs empower agents and agents need data, then any success of OpenAI Frontier in “unlocking” the value of corporate data is in our view probably a GOOD thing for Palantir, Databricks, Snowflake and MongoDB.

Valuation Method and Risk Statement

Investing in the technology sector entails above-average risk given low sales visibility, rapid pace of innovation and technological change, intense competition, frequent M&A, and low barriers to entry in many markets.

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12-Month Rating	Definition	Coverage ¹	IB Services ²
Buy	FSR is > 6% above the MRA.	52%	24%
Neutral	FSR is between -6% and 6% of the MRA.	41%	22%
Sell	FSR is > 6% below the MRA.	7%	25%
Short-Term Rating	Definition	Coverage ³	IB Services ⁴
Buy	Stock price expected to rise within three months from the time the rating was assigned because of a specific catalyst or event.	<1%	<1%
Sell	Stock price expected to fall within three months from the time the rating was assigned because of a specific catalyst or event.	<1%	<1%

Source: UBS. Rating allocations are as of 31 December 2025.

1:Percentage of companies under coverage globally within the 12-month rating category.

2:Percentage of companies within the 12-month rating category for which investment banking (IB) services were provided within the past 12 months.

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